

I47

Simon of Cyrene

A passer-by from Africa who was made to carry Jesus' cross.

Simon of Cyrene appears in only one verse in each of three Gospels. He was a man from Cyrene in North Africa, coming into Jerusalem "out of the country," when he met the procession leading Jesus to be crucified. The Roman soldiers seized him and forced him to carry Jesus' cross. Luke adds that he carried it "after Jesus," walking behind him. Mark names Simon's sons, Alexander and Rufus, as if his first readers knew them. That small detail has led many to think Simon's family later became believers. Simon did not choose his burden, but it put him closer to Jesus on the road to the cross than anyone else. His brief moment has become a picture of what it means to follow Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Simon, "a Cyrenian" (Mark 15:21)
Home	Cyrene, a city in North Africa, in modern Libya
Family	Father of Alexander and Rufus (Mark 15:21)
When	c. AD 30, the day of the crucifixion
Where	On the road out of Jerusalem to Golgotha
Known for	Carrying Jesus' cross
Main passages	Matthew 27:32; Mark 15:21; Luke 23:26

"And they compel one Simon a Cyrenian, who passed by, coming out of the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to bear his cross."

Mark 15:21, KJV

The life of Simon of Cyrene

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Scripture tells only this one episode of Simon's life.

Earlier	A man of Cyrene Simon comes from Cyrene in North Africa. Scripture does not say whether he lived in Jerusalem or had come as a pilgrim for Passover. Jews from Cyrene were among those in Jerusalem at the feasts. <i>Mark 15:21; Acts 2:10</i>
c. AD 30 <i>Friday morning</i>	Coming in from the country As the soldiers lead Jesus out to be crucified, Simon is passing by, "coming out of the country," and meets the procession on the road. <i>Mark 15:20-21; Luke 23:26</i>
The same hour	Compelled to carry the cross The soldiers lay hold on Simon and compel him to bear Jesus' cross. Luke says they laid it on him "that he might bear it after Jesus." <i>Matthew 27:32; Luke 23:26</i>
The same hour	At Golgotha They bring Jesus to Golgotha, which is, being interpreted, "The place of a skull." There they offer him wine mingled with myrrh and crucify him. <i>Mark 15:22-24</i>

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Simon of Cyrene.

Old Testament

Echoes	Isaac carries the wood for the offering up the mountain (Genesis 22:6). "Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows" (Isaiah 53:4).
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New Testament

Matthew 27:32; Mark 15:21; Luke 23:26	Three short accounts of Simon carrying the cross.
John 19:17	Jesus goes out bearing his cross.
Romans 16:13	Paul greets "Rufus chosen in the Lord, and his mother and mine." He may be Simon's son.
Acts 2:10; 6:9; 11:20; 13:1	Men of Cyrene are present at Pentecost, oppose Stephen, preach at Antioch, and lead in the church there.
Echoes	"If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me" (Luke 9:23). "Bear ye one another's burdens" (Galatians 6:2).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What details does Mark give about Simon that Matthew and Luke leave out (Mark 15:21)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Mark mentions Alexander and Rufus?
3. *Apply:* Simon did not choose his burden, yet it put him close to Jesus. How has an unwanted burden drawn you closer to God?
4. *Apply:* Whose burden could you help carry this week (Galatians 6:2)?